An Urban *Awakening*

Gujarati cinema is winning audiences and acclaim as it shifts from **rural narratives to stories and settings around lives in the city.** But limited resources and divided audiences pose a challenge

By Jumana Shah



MAKING A MARK Ratna Pathak Shah and Manasi Parekh in *Kutch Express*, which won three National Film Awards this year

A decade ago, when Raam Mori moved to Ahmedabad from a small village in Bhavnagar with the simple dream of writing for Gujarati serials, little did he know that not only would his calendar be packed with projects for three years in advance, but one of his films would also achieve national acclaim. In October 2024, *Kutch Express*, for which Mori wrote the dialogues, bagged three National Film Awards, including the best actress and costume design honours. Filmed in Kutch, the movie traces the journey of a woman who, betrayed by her husband, finds her voice in *lippan*—a traditional art form.

It's one of the many examples of how the Gujarati film industry has been in revival mode, culminating in six box-office hits since 2023 (see *The Big Earners*). While one of them— supernatural horror film *Vash* (2023)—was remade into the highly successful Hindi movie *Shaitaan* in 2024, there are